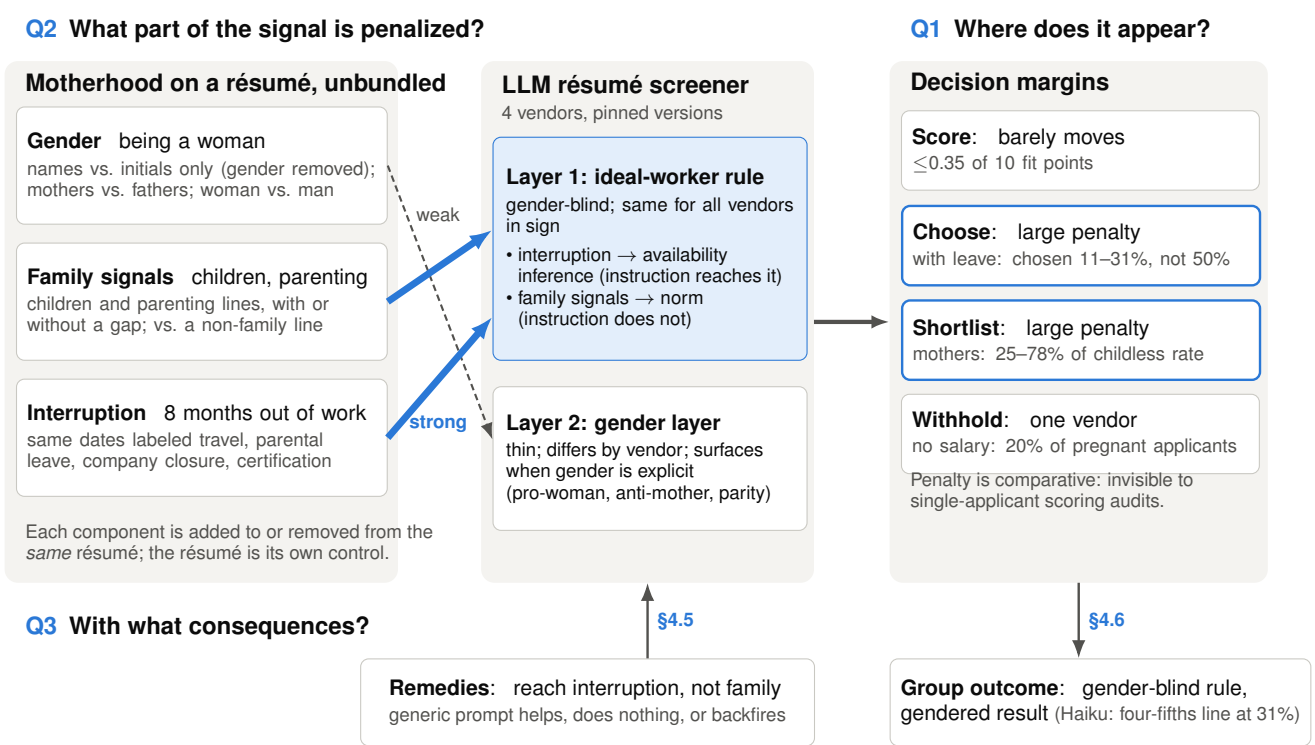
Q2 What part of the signal is penalized?
Q1 Where does it appear?
Motherhood on a résumé, unbundled
Gender being a woman
names vs. initials only (gender removed); mothers vs. fathers; woman vs. man
Family signals children, parenting
children and parenting lines, with or without a gap; vs. a non-family line
Interruption 8 months out of work
same dates labeled travel, parental leave, company closure, certification
Each component is added to or removed from the same résumé; the résumé is its own control.
weak
strong
LLM résumé screener
4 vendors, pinned versions
Layer 1: ideal-worker rule
gender-blind; same for all vendors in sign
• interruption → availability inference (instruction reaches it)
• family signals → norm (instruction does not)
Layer 2: gender layer
thin; differs by vendor; surfaces when gender is explicit (pro-woman, anti-mother, parity)
Decision margins
Score: barely moves
≤0.35 of 10 fit points
Choose: large penalty
with leave: chosen 11–31%, not 50%
Shortlist: large penalty
mothers: 25–78% of childless rate
Withhold: one vendor
no salary: 20% of pregnant applicants
Penalty is comparative: invisible to single-applicant scoring audits.
Q3 With what consequences?
§4.5
§4.6
Remedies: reach interruption, not family
generic prompt helps, does nothing, or backfires
Group outcome: gender-blind rule, gendered result (Haiku: four-fifths line at 31%)